Phishing Awareness Training

CodeAlpha Cyber Security Internship, Task 2

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What is phishing?

- It’s a fake messages that pretend to be from someone you trust, like a bank, your boss, or a delivery company.
- They want you to click a link, open a file, share a password, or send money.
- They come by email, SMS, calls, WhatsApp, and social media.
- Attackers are after passwords, money, personal data, or a way to install malware.

Why Phishing Matters?

- Phishing Attacks go after people, so software alone can’t stop them.
- The human element was involved in 62% of breaches, phishing was behind 16% of breaches.
- One click can mean a stolen account, lost money, or ransomware spreading across the network.

Source: Verizon 2026 DBIR

How to spot a phishing email (1 of 2): Check the sender and the message

- The sender's address is a look-alike, like support@examplebank-alerts.com, or a free Gmail pretending to be a bank
- Urgent or scary wording message, like "Your account will be closed in 24 hours".
- A generic greeting like "Dear customer" (but a real name doesn't prove it's safe).
- The link doesn't match the text, so hover or press and hold to see the real address first.

How to spot a phishing email (2 of 2): Check what it asks for

- Unexpected attachments, especially .zip, .exe, or Office files asking you to enable macros.
- Requests for passwords, PINs, OTPs, or card details, which a real bank never asks for this way.
- Offers that are too good to be true, like prizes or jobs that ask for a fee.
- A message with no spelling mistakes isn’t automatically safe, since attackers now write clean messages, even with AI.

How to spot a fake website

- Check the domain, examplebank-login.com is not examplebank.com.
- The real domain is the part just before .com, so examplebank.fake-site.com belongs to fake-site.com.
- The padlock only means the connection is encrypted, and phishing sites can have it too.
- Be careful with poor design, a login page you reached from a message, or requests for too much information.
- Safest habit when you type the address yourself, when you use a bookmark, or when you use the official app.

Types of phishing

- Email phishing: This is mass messages sent to lots of people.
- Spear phishing: It aimed at one person, using their name and job
- Smishing: This type of phishing is by SMS or WhatsApp.
- Vishing: This is a phone call from someone pretending to be your bank or an official.
- Business email compromise: This is a fake message from a boss or supplier asking for an urgent payment.
- Voice and SMS attacks were 40% more successful than email, so don't relax just because it isn't an email.
  Source: Verizon 2026 DBIR (as reported)

Social engineering tactics

- Attackers play on feelings, not technical tricks.
- Urgency: “Act now or lose access”.
  Fear: “Your account has been hacked” or “legal action”.
  Authority: like posing as a boss, bank, police, or IT.
  Greed: like prizes, grants, free money.
  Curiosity: “You won’t believe this photo” or a mystery parcel.
  Trust: a friend’s hacked account, or details about you to look real.
- They want you to act before you think.

Real-world examples

- **Google and Facebook invoice scam (2013 to 2015):** A man posed as the Taiwanese hardware maker Quanta Computer and emailed fake payment requests to both companies, who paid out more than $100 million. *Lesson learnt: is that even big companies fall for fake invoices*. **Source: NPR, March 2019**
- **Twitter hack (July 2020):** Attackers targeted a small number of employees with a phone spear phishing attack, got into internal tools, and took over high-profile accounts for a bitcoin scam. *Lesson learnt: is that phone calls can be phishing too.* **Source: Twitter's security update, July 2020**
- **Common scam patterns in Nigeria** (not named incidents): A fake bank SMS with a link, a "grant" or "palliative" message, a fake job offer that asks for a fee, and someone asking you to send back a code "sent by mistake" on WhatsApp.

Best practices

- Stop and think before you click, especially when a message rushes you.
  Check the sender’s address and the link first.
  Verify another way: call the number on your bank card, or use the official website or app.
  Never share passwords, PINs, or OTPs.
  Use multi-factor authentication and a different password for each account.
  Don’t open unexpected attachments.
  Keep your phone and computer updated.
  Report suspicious messages to your IT or security team, or your bank.

What to do if you clicked

- Don’t panic, and don’t enter any more details.
  If you typed a password, change it right away, and anywhere else you used it.
  Turn on multi-factor authentication.
  Tell your IT or security team, or your bank, straight away.
  Run a malware scan.
  If you sent money, call your bank immediately.
  Watch your accounts for strange activity.

Test Yourself

- The quiz has 6 questions and shows your score at the end. https://forms.gle/Y4djRBVCfoYjZ3rRA



Summary

- Stop before you click.
- Check the sender and the link.
- Verify another way.
- Report it.
- If in doubt, don’t click.